The Monroe Doctrine

President James Monroe · Seventh Annual Message to Congress · December 2, 1823

Source: James Monroe, Seventh Annual Message to Congress (Dec. 2, 1823), text via The American Presidency Project, UC Santa Barbara. Public domain.

Latin American independence movements in the 1810s–20s left several new republics (Mexico, Colombia, Argentina, Chile) vulnerable to European reconquest. With the encouragement of Secretary of State John Quincy Adams, Monroe announced — inside a routine annual message to Congress — that the Western Hemisphere was closed to further European colonization and that the U.S. would view interference as an act of hostility. Tacitly underwritten by the British Royal Navy, the doctrine became a long-term foundation of U.S. foreign policy.

Connect: The Era of Good Feelings ended fast. What tensions from Class 8 (Missouri Compromise, sectionalism) helped destroy it?

Key Passages

Non-colonization

the American continents, by the free and independent condition which they have assumed and maintain, are henceforth not to be considered as subjects for future colonization by any European powers.

Two political systems

we should consider any attempt on their part to extend their system to any portion of this hemisphere as dangerous to our peace and safety. … we could not view any interposition for the purpose of oppressing them, or controlling in any other manner their destiny, by any European power in any other light than as the manifestation of an unfriendly disposition toward the United States.

Non-intervention pledge

Our policy in regard to Europe, which was adopted at an early stage of the wars which have so long agitated that quarter of the globe, nevertheless remains the same, which is, not to interfere in the internal concerns of any of its powers

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Independence movements in Latin America (1810s-20s) left new republics vulnerable to European reconquest, and Russia was pressing claims in the Pacific Northwest.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Congress and the American public, and indirectly the European powers, especially the Holy Alliance, Russia, and Britain.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	President James Monroe, with Secretary of State John Quincy Adams, representing a young, militarily weak United States that wanted influence in its own hemisphere.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. Contextualization (DBQ/LEQ, 1 pt): In one paragraph, place the Monroe Doctrine in the broader post-Napoleonic, post-Latin-American-independence context of the 1820s.
2. Why did the U.S. have the audacity — but not really the power — to issue this declaration in 1823?
3. Trace ONE later application of the Monroe Doctrine (e.g., Polk, Roosevelt Corollary, Cold War interventions).

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> Monroe declared the Western Hemisphere closed to further European colonization and warned that any such interference would be seen as a threat — a cornerstone of U.S. foreign policy.

Non-colonization

At the proposal of the Russian Imperial Government, made through the minister of the Emperor residing here, a full power and instructions have been transmitted to the minister of the United States at St. Petersburg to arrange by amicable negotiation the respective rights and interests of the two nations on the North West coast of this continent. . . . In the discussions to which this interest has given rise and in the arrangements by which they may terminate the occasion has been judged proper for asserting, as a principle in which the rights and interests of the United States are involved, that the American continents, by the free and independent condition which they have assumed and maintain, are henceforth not to be considered as subjects for future colonization by any European powers.

[. . .]

Europe and America: two political systems

Of events in that quarter of the globe, with which we have so much intercourse and from which we derive our origin, we have always been anxious and interested spectators.

The citizens of the United States cherish sentiments the most friendly in favor of the liberty and happiness of their fellow men on that side of the Atlantic. In the wars of the European powers in matters relating to themselves we have never taken any part, nor does it comport with our policy so to do.

It is only when our rights are invaded or seriously menaced that we resent injuries or make preparation for our defense. With the movements in this hemisphere we are of necessity more immediately connected, and by causes which must be obvious to all enlightened and impartial observers.

The political system of the allied powers is essentially different in this respect from that of America. This difference proceeds from that which exists in their respective Governments; and to the defense of our own, which has been achieved by the loss of so much blood and treasure, and matured by the wisdom of their most enlightened citizens, and under which we have enjoyed unexampled felicity, this whole nation is devoted.

We owe it, therefore, to candor and to the amicable relations existing between the United States and those powers to declare that we should consider any attempt on their part to extend their system to any portion of this hemisphere as dangerous to our peace and safety. With the existing colonies or dependencies of any European power we have not interfered and shall not interfere, but with the Governments who have declared their independence and maintained it, and whose independence we have, on great consideration and on just principles, acknowledged, we could not view any interposition for the purpose of oppressing them, or controlling in any other manner their destiny, by any European power in any other light than as the manifestation of an unfriendly disposition toward the United States.

[. . .]

Non-intervention pledge

The late events in Spain and Portugal shew that Europe is still unsettled. Of this important fact no stronger proof can be adduced than that the allied powers should have thought it proper, on any principle satisfactory to themselves, to have interposed by force in the internal concerns of Spain. . . . Our policy in regard to Europe, which was adopted at an early stage of the wars which have so long agitated that quarter of the globe, nevertheless remains the same, which is, not to interfere in the internal concerns of any of its powers; to consider the government de facto as the legitimate government for us; to cultivate friendly relations with it, and to preserve those relations by a frank, firm, and manly policy, meeting in all instances the just claims of every power, submitting to injuries from none.

But in regard to those continents circumstances are eminently and conspicuously different. It is impossible that the allied powers should extend their political system to any portion of either continent without endangering our peace and happiness; nor can anyone believe that our southern brethren, if left to themselves, would adopt it of their own accord. It is equally impossible, therefore, that we should behold such interposition in any form with indifference.

Words to know

amicable — friendly

colonization — a European power taking and settling territory as its possession

comport with — fit with; be consistent with

allied powers — the European monarchies (Russia, Austria, Prussia, France) allied after Napoleon

interposition — interference by a European power in an independent nation's affairs

de facto — actually in power, whether or not legally recognized